The Many Hats of Herodotus:

Examining *Histories'* Pursuit of Moral Agenda Through Subject Breadth

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While interpretations of Herodotus' *Histories* are widespread, scholars generally agree upon one point: its composition is one of a kind. The *Histories* intertwines battle narratives, anthropology, folklore, geography, and politics into a monolithic "display of inquiry" written to ensure that "human achievements may not become forgotten in time" (Herodotus et al. 1.1.1).[1] Within his definition of "human achievement", Herodotus also includes description of native and foreign culture, interaction with the divine, and manipulation of physical resources. Given the modern academic mindset of narrowing in on a specific subject, it is easy to pigeonhole Herodotus' work into a particular category. However, Herodotus lived during a period of enlightenment where intellectuals often meddled in various schools of interest.[2] Keeping this societal contrast in mind, we must remind ourselves that viewing *Histories* as a distinct genre to the exclusion of others arbitrarily reduces the work to just one of its ingredients.[3] Furthermore, we must recognize that creating retrojections based on modern thought excludes the text's multidimensional texture.[4] If we consider commonalities between Herodotus' ethnographies, oracular warnings, and diverse digressions, we notice that he frequently seasons passages with moral wisdoms and lessons. While these messages vary, the ultimate combination Herodotus stews together is rich with depth and flavor. In this paper, I argue that while *Histories* is unquestionably a work of great breadth, Herodotus' primary objective is to *make use of* its multifaceted complexity to push a moral agenda to broader audiences, especially to those less receptive to foreign strengths.[5]

While reading *Histories*, we slowly adjust to Herodotus' structure and persistent pauses. By the time we reach the story of King Cambyses and his disrespect of Egyptian culture, we have already grown accustomed to Herodotus' interjections:

> In view of all this, I have no doubt whatever that Cambyses was completely out of his mind; it is the only possible explanation of his assault upon, and mockery of, everything which ancient law and custom have made sacred in Egypt. (3.38)

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[1] Throughout the text, I will cite Herodotus' work shorthand in the format (X.xx.ii) using the *Penguin Classics* translation by Aubrey, De Sélincourt and edited by John Marincola. See Herodotus, De Sélincourt, Aubrey, and Marincola, John. *The Histories*. Rev. Ed. / Revised with Introduction and Notes by John Marincola. ed. Penguin Classics. London: Penguin, 2003.

[2] An example of a versatile 5th century thinker is Hippodamus of Miletus, who made significant contributions in both urban planning and political philosophy. See Roger Paden, "The two professions of Hippodamus of Miletus", *Philosophy and geography* 4, no. 1 (2001), 4: 26

[3] Egbert J. Bakker, "The syntax of historiē: How Herodotus writes," in *The Cambridge Companion to Herodotus*, eds. Carolyn Dewald and John Marincola (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press), 92.

[4] Bakker, *The syntax of historiē*, 92.

[5] Carolyn Dewald and John Marincola, "Introduction," in *The Cambridge Companion to Herodotus*, eds. Carolyn Dewald and John Marincola (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press), 6.

However, the following statement comes as a shock, interrupting the pattern we previously constructed:

> "For if anyone, no matter who, were given the opportunity of choosing from amongst all the nations in the world the beliefs which he thought best, he would inevitably, after careful consideration of their relative merits, choose those of his own country." (3.38)

Throughout *Histories*, Herodotus makes few general statements about humankind from an omniscient narrator's perspective. We see moral truths scattered throughout every book. Herodotus states that "men are at the mercy of circumstance, and not their master" through the voice of Artabanas (7.49). A conversation between Solon and Croesus tells us that "great wealth can make a man no happier than moderate means, unless he has the luck to continue in prosperity to the end" (1.32).[6] Herodotus rarely endorses views explicitly. Instead, he crafts the narrative structure deliberately so that his characters subtly learn from moral lessons, which are of his own manipulation.[7] Artabanas' words of warning come prior to Xerxes' expedition to invade Greece which, even given Persian advantage, ultimately falls at the mercy of circumstance (7.223-231). Croesus disregards Solon's wise words about the transience of human fortune and later falls at the mercy of desolation (1.85-88).[8] Or, Herodotus uses roundabout criticism, as in 1.131 when he suggests that the Persians do not accept the erection of religious structures and that "anyone who does such a thing is considered a fool".[9]

When Herodotus *does* provide explicit opinions, he tends to limit them in scope to particular nations, people, or situations—rarely humankind in general.[10] Given that he employs techniques that avoid explicit moral advice throughout *Histories*, Herodotus' choice to be direct in 3.37-38 is unusual. The passage's message that a person would take the "beliefs which he thought best", then "inevitably" choose "those of his own country" suggests that Herodotus has taken on some form of critical inquiry into cognitive bias, then subsequently expresses his findings sophistically (3.38).[11] If

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[6] According to the chronology of Greek history, the Herodotean encounter between Solon and Croesus does not fit the timeline. See Book 1 Note 18 in Herodotus, et al., The Histories (London: Penguin Classics, 2003).
[7] Lisa Irene Hau, "Herodotus" in *Moral History from Herodotus to Diodorus Siculus* (Edinburgh University Press, 2016), 178-179.
[8] Susan O. Shapiro. "Herodotus and Solon." *Classical Antiquity* 15, no. 2 (1996): 355.
[9] Scott Scullion, "Herodotus and Greek religion" in *The Cambridge Companion to Herodotus*, eds. Carolyn Dewald and John Marincola (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press), 202.
[10] See 5.78 for how democracy strengthened the Athenians. See 8.105-106 for how Hermotimus acts in response to Panionius' unholy trade. See 5.49-51 for the story of how Gorgo advises her father not to trust Aristagoras of Miletus.
[11] For further information on cognitive bias, see Jean-Paul Caverni, Jean-Marc Fabre, and Michel Gonzalez. "Cognitive Biases: Their Contribution for Understanding Human Cognitive Processes." In *Advances in Psychology* 68 (1990): 7-12.

we examine the surrounding context, we notice that Herodotus' message is several layers deep: it is a moral statement nested within a historical digression within an ethnographical digression within a battle narrative. This then begs the question, how often does *Histories* tie together different genres to express a moral message? Scholars such as Lisa Irene Hau have sought to categorize the moralizing techniques of historiographers—including Herodotus—into categories of expression such as narrative pauses, evaluative phrasing, and moralizing vignettes.[12] While Hau's classifications call attention to Herodotus' subtle moral messages, we explore how Herodotus purposefully takes advantage of the *Histories'* subject breadth to push his moral agenda.

Throughout Herodotus' discussions of other cultures, we learn significant information from inquiries carried out during his travels. Much like a modern day ethnographer, Herodotus steps into another culture and evaluates its societies, gathering evidence through observations and interviews. However, a slight difference is that ethnographers approach their work in a non-judgemental framework, while Herodotus tends to provide brief but binary opinions.[13] Herodotus speaks highly of the Egyptians' observance of piety (2.65) and praises the Persians' progressive political checks and balances (1.137). He acknowledges that the Egyptians are capable of developing technology to control natural resources (2.99), and treads more carefully when describing the Callatiae custom of eating dead parents (3.38). Even brief vignettes, such as the story of how Ethiopians learned Egyptian manners (2.30), contribute to an understanding that we are human beings who have much to learn from each other. Furthermore, Herodotus' choice to narrate the *Histories* with tragic stories and oracular warnings is by far the most common method used to relay his moral messages. We frequently find ourselves better understanding right and wrong choices through the lenses of Herodotus' characters. By envisioning Gyges warning King Caundales not to reveal his wife's body (1.8-9) or Artabanus attempting to reason with Xerxes (7.10) or power-hungry kings ignoring oracle after oracle (1.46-56, 7.140-143), we find broad moral themes outlining the transience of human

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For parallels between *The Histories* and sophist ideologies, see generally Kurt A. Raaflaub, "Philosophy, Science, Politics: Herodotus and the Intellectual Trends of his Time" in *Brill's Companion to Herodotus,* eds. Egbert J. Bakker, Irene J.F. de Jong, and Hans van Wees (The Netherlands: Brill, 2002): 154-179; Rosalind Thomas, *Herodotus in Context : Ethnography, Science and the Art of Persuasion* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2000).

[12] An example of a narrative pause occurs when Herodotus puases the narrative to inject his own view on sex in temples: "Such is the theory, but, in spite of it, I must continue to disapprove the practice" (2.65). See Hau, *Herodotus,* 175.

[13] See Jennifer T. Roberts, "Herodotus as ethnographer" in *Herodotus: A Very Short Introduction* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011).

fortune and uncertainty of human life. Given this motif of failures leading to lessons learned, we can easily elect Herodotus as the *Histories'* ultimate wise adviser.[14]

Recurring patterns within Herodotus' storytelling framework introduce an interrelationship between his distinctive combination of topics and his moral agenda. Besides the written text, we lack knowledge of Herodotus' motives. However, we can break down narrative evidence using logic and deduction to show that Herodotus deliberately exploits his subject matter to push a moral agenda. By incorporating concepts from computer science and mathematics, we demonstrate that some of Herodotus' most criticized stylistic choices are mere consequences of his true intentions.

One of Herodotus' most well known criticisms comes from Thucydides, who claims to have written his *History of the Peloponnesian War* as "a possession of lasting value" and not as a work "competing for an immediate hearing".[15] While scholars generally consider Thucydides to be Herodotus' successor, his records are much more similar to history by contemporary standards. If we consider that Herodotus also introduces *Histories* as an inquiry so that "human achievements may not become forgotten in time" (1.1.1), we are left to wonder, why would he choose to cloud his logos with stories of giant gold-digging ants (3.103) and observations of skull thickness (3.12)? In the following paragraphs, we will consider a Herodotean choice which has puzzled scholars, then provide evidence that the choice supports his moral agenda. By deduction, we will steadily present interactions with other subject matter as proof that Herodotus' objective is to showcase moral wisdoms.

We first ask, why does Herodotus spend so much time discussing other cultures? Besides his genuine interest in these foreign places and people, his descriptions are essential to our understanding of how other cultures compared to each other at the time in terms of religion, resources, and values.[16] It is likely that Herodotus' travels—exploring unfamiliar terrain, hearing interesting stories, and experiencing different cultural norms—affected him much like it would a modern individual transported across the world. These experiences likely expanded his worldview and taught him to look outside his own bubble, much like globalization has affected the extent of

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[14] Scholars frequently describe characters such as Solon or Artabanas as tragic warners or "wise advisers". See Richmond Lattimore. "The Wise Adviser in Herodotus." *Classical Philology* 34, no. 1 (1939): 24–35.
[15] J. A. S. Evans. "Father of History or Father of Lies; The Reputation of Herodotus." in *The Classical Journal (Classical Association of the Middle West and South)* 64, no. 1 (1968): 12-13.
[16] John Gould. *Herodotus*. [Historians on Historians] (New York: St. Martin's Press, 1989): 7-10.

prejudice in modern communities.[17] Given the rewards of travel, it is quite plausible that Herodotus sought to effect change within his own society by sending implicit messages about lessons he learned.

Why does Herodotus end *Histories* so abruptly? As a historical narrative of the Persian Wars, the *Histories* is incomplete. However, debate remains over if Herodotus' work is unfinished or if the capture of Sestos ending sends a tactful message.[18] Some scholars have delved deeply into the archaic text to analyze patterns such as a "ring-composition".[19] Regardless of the ending's literary meaning, his choice to end with an ambiguous epigram is bizarre. For someone claiming to display an inquiry so that "great and marvelous deeds" are not "without their glory", this ending is quite unsatisfying. However, considering the complexity of topics and lessons Herodotus already covers throughout *Histories*, it would not be shocking to learn that he felt his message was heard.

And finally, why does Herodotus choose to write such a long piece of work? According to Bakker, its length is both unprecedented in Greek history and not followed by his historiographical successors.[20] If Herodotus had planned to write a modern day "history" book, we could have learned about the battles during the Persian Wars much more efficiently. If Herodotus had planned to write an ethnography of different cultures he encountered during his travels, he could have done away with the extensive vignettes about specific Persian, Egyptian, or Greek leaders we encounter, or at least shortened them to relate actions to particular cultures. If Herodotus had planned to write about interesting folklore that sources recounted, he could have done so without such in-depth analysis of geography, politics, and battle. If his motive was to focus on any one, two or three of these subjects, it is difficult to rationalize the need for such a comprehensive work.

Although *Histories* is written in an informal style, its carefully articulated structure suggests that the work was well-thought out, with digressions meant to accomplish a goal. If we visualize each of the subject areas within Herodotus' work as a dependency graph, we notice that different subject areas can depend on each other—ethnography may depend on discussion of history, geography, folklore, and religion, but has little relationship to battle narratives; battle narratives may

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[17] A 2012 psychological study showed that cultural exposure reduced stereotypes and intergroup bias. Hong, Ying-yi, and Cheon, Bobby K. "How Does Culture Matter in the Face of Globalization?" Perspectives on Psychological Science 12, no. 5 (2017): 814

[18] John Herington. "The Closure of Herodotus' "Histories"." Illinois Classical Studies 16, no. 1/2 (1991): 149.

[19] While I do not endorse this analysis, it is an interesting read. Herington. *The Closure of Herodotus' "Histories"*, 151.

[20] Bakker, *The syntax of historiē*, 94.

depend on history and geography, but require little need for folklore or ethnography. In considering different genres that scholars have considered *Histories* a part of, only moral wisdoms can make use of all of the subject areas combined.[21]

Herodotus' methods of injecting moral wisdom into Histories all relied on the structure of his story. For instance, Cambyses' linear succession of Cyrus (2.1.1) and decision to wage war on Egypt (2.1.3) provided an opportunity for Herodotus to bring up an anthropological account of Egypt. The anthropological account of Egypt allowed Herodotus to discuss Egyptian customs, religion, geography, and folklore—all of which provides the audience with a better understanding of how Egyptians live. It also allows him to personalize individuals in Egyptian history and showcase their humanity. Herodotus then recurses back to Cambyses' time to describe the battles between Persians and Egyptians, using the timeline to jump backward and forward like traversing a recursive tree.[22] Given the fluidity with which Herodotus weaves his story, we barely notice how The *Histories* gradually changes our perception of different peoples through history. In this sense, no detail is superfluous. For example, the audience's understanding of the Egyptians' capabilities (2.35) might increase their skepticism of the Greek version (6.53) of the Spartan royal house's genealogy compared to that of the Persian version (6.54-55). On that same vein, if we were to strip Histories of the narrative and consider just the moral lessons, we would find an entanglement of insights with seemingly no connection—a tasteless tale to hear performed, too proverbial for the average person to find much meaning. Ultimately, *Histories* leaves us with morally memorable stories and a richer understanding of human beings at a time when globalization did not exist. By discerning *Histories'* breadth as a deliberate style choice, we reshape our understanding of what "Herodotean" narration is.

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[21] A dependency graph is frequently used in computer science to show the dependency of an entity in a system on other entities of the same system. I have attached a hand-drawn example for visual reference, but note that the figure's subject area nodes are not exhaustive. See diagram of dependency graph.

[22] A recursive tree traversal is commonly used to explore nodes in a graph, then return back to the root in order to explore other tangential nodes. See "Binary Tree Traversals using Recursion - Preorder, Inorder and Postorder," *Enjoy Algorithms*, https://www.enjoyalgorithms.com/blog/binary-tree-traversals-preorder-inorder-postorder (accessed September 19, 2021) for a useful visualization.

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